



President "Lula"

The first working-class president in Brazil's history, Luiz Inácio Lula da Silva came to power in 2003 pledging to abolish hunger by putting three meals a day on the plates of every Brazilian. In 2006 he was reelected with more than 60 percent of the vote, despite a corruption scandal that tarnished his reputation as a reformer.

1968 In the face of student protests and criticism from the church against military rule, the new military ruler, Marshall Costa E. Silva, dismisses Congress and assumes one-man rule.

1969 General Emílio Garrastazú Médici becomes president. Left- and right-wing terrorism, including the capture of several diplomats, becomes a feature of Brazilian politics.

1973 World oil crisis marks the end of the economic boom. Brazil's foreign debt is now the largest in world.

1978 All emergency legislation is ended.

1979 More political parties are allowed as military rule is relaxed and moves are made toward democracy.

1979–85 Period of massive industrial and economic growth.

1980 Huge migrations into Rondônia state begin.

1985 Civilian senator Tancredo Neves appointed president after vote of electoral college but dies before taking office. Illiterate adults are given the vote. José Sarney takes over.

1987 Gold found on Yanomami lands in Roraima state in the Amazon region. Illegal diggers rush in by the thousands, threatening the way of life of the indigenous Yanomami.

1988 New constitution provides for freedom of assembly, the right to strike, and a reduction in the working week, and promises massive social spending but fails to address land reform. Chico Mendes, the rubber-tappers' union leader and leading environmentalist, is murdered.

1989 Brazil's first environmental protection plan is drawn up. Annual inflation reaches 1,000 percent.

1990 Fernando Collor de Mello wins first fully democratic presidential elections, and, after increasing international pressure, sponsors programs to decrease the rate of deforestation in the Amazon basin and protect the autonomy of the native Yanomami people.

1992 Earth Summit is held in Rio de Janeiro, the world's first such summit. Collor de Mello resigns and is impeached for corruption; he is the first Brazilian president to be impeached by Congress.

1993 Brazilians vote in a referendum to retain the direct election of the president.

1994–95 Plan Real ends hyperinflation. Congress resists constitutional reforms, but approves privatizations of state monopolies.

1999 Fernando Henrique Cardoso, in power since 1995, is reelected president. Real devalued in economic crisis.

2000 Economy recovers. Ruling parties divide over elections of the heads of Congress.

2001–02 Recovery of the economy threatened by financial crisis in Argentina.

2003 At his fourth attempt, Luiz Inácio Lula da Silva, the leader of the left-wing Workers' Party (PT) wins the presidential election and becomes the country's first working-class president. He is elected on a social platform to fight poverty and hunger, but in office his policies resemble those of his predecessors.

2004 Brazil launches its first space rocket. Bids for a permanent seat on the UN Security Council.

2006 Brazil announces that it expects to become energy self-sufficient by the end of the year. Brazil's ethanol industry (making car fuel from sugar cane) makes it a world leader in cutting carbon emissions. Lula is reelected president despite accusations of corruption.

2007 Criminal proceedings relating to the Mensalão "votes for cash" scandal continue.

2008 Brazil declines invitation to join OPEC.

2010 Dilma Rousseff of the Worker's Party wins second-round run-off election and becomes Brazil's first female president.

«280–81 The Slave Trade
«318–19 Latin America Liberated
«422–23 Viva la Revolución

Paraguay



Landlocked and with few natural resources, Paraguay has a long history of despotic rule.

1526 Spanish first explore the upper reaches of the Paraguay River and surrounding region.

1537 Sailing up the Paraná River in search of silver and a way across the continent, the Spaniards establish a fort at Asunción, which becomes the capital of La Plata province. The Guaraní, settled agriculturalists who live in the Paraguay river basin, help the Spanish conquer the southern Chaco area, home to nomadic hunters who raid Guaraní settlements.

1617 Hernando Arias de Saavedra, governor of Río de la Plata province, splits Paraguay away from Argentina.

1721–31 Temporary independence from Spain as José de Antequera leads a revolt.

1767 The Jesuits, who arrived in 1588 and organized the Amerindians into mission communities, are expelled.

1776 Region made part of the Viceroyalty of Río de la Plata.

1810 Manuel Belgrano is unsuccessful in carrying over the Argentinian revolt against Spanish rule into Paraguay.

1811 The Spanish administration is quietly deposed. Paraguay is now independent. Over the next 50 years, it is ruled by dictatorships and cut off from the outside world. It is protected from the unrest affecting its neighbors and becomes an economic power.

1814–40 José Gaspar Rodríguez Francia —"El Supremo"—rules the country with corruption-free but harsh rule. He is the first of three dictators that dominate the history of the country.



General Stroessner

Dictator from 1954 until he was deposed in 1989, General Alfredo Stroessner was the son of German immigrants and a virulent anticommunist who used torture and kidnappings to sustain his rule.

1844–62 Carlos Antonio López becomes dictator. His son Francisco succeeds him, but brings about disaster with the War of the Triple Alliance.

1864–70 Paraguay loses the War of the Triple Alliance against Argentina, Brazil, and Uruguay and eventually loses land to Brazil and Argentina, with a further loss in 1880 to Bolivia. More than two-thirds of its population (300,000) are killed in the war, plunging the country into a lengthy period of economic decline. Recovery is slow as warring *caudillos* set up short-lived dictatorships.

1932–35 The Chaco War against Bolivia over the disputed Chaco territory, where the supposed discovery of oil held out the promise of great wealth in this once-barren region.

1938 Boundary with Bolivia is fixed; Paraguay awarded large tracts of land. The country emerges victorious but exhausted after the conflict.

1940–48 A rapid turnover of governments ends when Higinio Morínigo holds power. His repressive, dictatorial rule is challenged by numerous uprisings.

1954–89 Rule of Alfredo Stroessner. His repressive military regime stifles opposition and rigs elections to win repeated electoral success.

1973 Brazil and Paraguay agree to build a massive hydroelectric project on the Paraná River at Itaipú; it is the world's second-largest such project.

1989 Despite winning an eighth term in 1988, General Stroessner is overthrown in a coup and is replaced by the coup's leader, General Andrés Rodríguez.

1993 First coup attempt by General Lino Oviedo, the former army chief, fails, as do further attempts in 1996 and 2000.

1994–95 Congress tries but fails to limit the powers of the military after the president, Juan Carlos Wasmosy, endorses the military's political and institutional role.

1998–99 Colorado Party (PC) president Raúl Cubas resigns after Congress votes to impeach him for the assassination of the vice president, Luis Argaña; Cubas and Oviedo leave the country.

2003 Nicanor Duarte Frutos of the PC wins presidential election.

2004 Oviedo returns from exile hoping to stand in the 2008 presidential election, but is arrested on arrival.

2008 Fernando Lugo, a former Roman Catholic bishop becomes president, ending Colorado Party's 60 years of rule. He accuses his predecessor Lino Oviedo of plotting against him and is embroiled in a controversy over his alleged fathering of children while a bishop.

«438–39 Dictatorship and Democracy